

NSQ NATIONAL STANDARDS FOR QUALITY ONLINE TEACHING



VIRTUAL LEARNING
LEADERSHIP ALLIANCE



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NATIONAL STANDARDS FOR QUALITY ONLINE TEACHING

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Version 4.1



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For more information or to contact the NSQ Project
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The National Standards for Quality Online Teaching has been the benchmark for quality online instruction since its introduction in 2007. DLAC, the Community Advancing Digital Learning, the Virtual Learning Leadership Alliance (VLLA) and Quality Matters™ organized a committee of experts with various backgrounds in the field of K-12 online learning to take the lead in revising the National Standards for Quality Online Teaching previously updated and maintained by iNACOL.

These dedicated educators represent organizations that share an interest in online education and believe that it is important that students have access to the highest quality online teachers. Many people contributed in significant ways to the research and writing effort required for this revision of

the National Standards for Quality Online Teaching.

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PREFACE

The National Standards for Quality Online Teaching is one of three standard sets within the National Standards for Quality Online Learning (NSQOL). The companion standard sets are the National Standards for Quality Online Courses and National Standards for Quality Online Programs. Designed to complement one another, these standard sets have served as benchmarks for online learning programs, districts, and state agencies since 2007 when they were originally published by The International Association for K-12 Online Learning (iNACOL). The openly licensed standard sets are utilized to evaluate and improve online courses, teaching, and programs. The standards are designed with flexibility, allowing leaders to adapt them to meet the unique needs of various program types. Several states have incorporated the NSQOL into legislation, state rules, or adopted them as criteria for assessing and approving online learning programs, instruction, and course content.

In 2018, under the direction of Quality Matters™ and the Virtual Learning Leadership Alliance (VLLA), the three standard sets underwent an extensive review and revision process, culminating in updated versions released in 2019. In 2021, the Digital Learning Collaborative (DLC), now known as DLAC joined Quality Matters and VLLA as co-stewards of the standards, ensuring they remain current and relevant to the evolving field of online learning.

In 2023, under the guidance of the NSQ Leadership Team, an evaluation of the standards began. In recognition of the post-pandemic changes in the online learning landscape, the evaluation began with an examination of current research in the field of online learning and NSQOL usage and satisfaction data gathered through surveys and focus groups. Project co-chairs Rachel McBroom and Wendy Oliver determined the NSQOL remained highly relevant, valuable, and comprehensive, and suggested that the NSQ Online Teaching would benefit from a full revision. The revision

process emphasized consolidating and clarifying indicators, reorganizing the standards for greater usability, and updating the Explanations to **Statements of Intent** and Examples to **Examples of Application**, with the goal of better articulating each standard's purpose and providing expanded practical applications to enhance understanding of the indicators' intent and meaning.

Outreach to practitioners and researchers in online learning yielded a revision team with experts from a wide variety of organizations, including statewide and regional online learning programs, state virtual schools, consortia, regional service agencies, state departments of education, district online and blended learning programs, full-time virtual schools, universities, private companies, and nonprofit organizations. The team included professionals from across the United States and representation from three international locations. The team is thanked for their dedication to the revision process and has been included in the acknowledgment section of this document. After eighteen months of research, conversation, writing, and revision, the updated National Standards for Quality Online Teaching is ready for publication.

The release of the 2025 National Standards for Quality Online Teaching is an affirmation of the commitment of DLAC, Quality Matters, and the VLLA, and project contributors to the continuous improvement of all three standard sets. Given the dynamic nature of online learning, the standards must be regularly updated to serve as meaningful benchmarks for teachers, leaders, schools, districts, statewide programs, and commercial suppliers of online learning.

For detailed information on the review process, a crosswalk comparing the 2019 and 2025 versions, a glossary and resources to support the implementation of the standards, please visit www.nsqol.org.

STATEMENT ON EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES

The committees responsible for the review of and updates to the National Standards for Quality Online Learning (NSQOL) acknowledge the likelihood that generative artificial intelligence (AI) will prove to be a powerful agent of change in the design, implementation, and use of digital learning at all levels. While this refresh of the NSQOL standards does not explicitly address AI and other emerging technologies, their implementation must align with applicable

local, state, and national policies and regulations, given the rapidly evolving landscape of guidance and practices in this area. As stewards of the NSQOL standards, we are committed to remaining responsive to advancements in the field and their implications for education. To support educators and institutions in navigating these transformative technologies, we will provide updated guidance and resources through the Resources section of the NSQOL website.

INTRODUCTION

The National Standards for Quality Online Teaching provides a robust framework designed to guide schools, districts, state agencies, statewide online programs, and other educational organizations in enhancing online teaching and learning. With the dynamic nature of instructional philosophies, approaches, and models in online teaching, the standards aim to offer clear guidance while maintaining flexibility to adapt to a variety of contexts.

This updated edition consolidates the standards into five key categories:

- **Standard A: Professional Responsibilities**
- **Standard B: Digital Citizenship**
- **Standard C: Engagement and Belonging**
- **Standard D: Learner-Centered Instruction**
- **Standard E: Instructional Design**

Each standard is supported by specific indicators, offering a detailed view of what constitutes quality online teaching. The revised standards also include the intent behind each indicator (the why) and practical applications (the how), providing educators with actionable insights for implementation. These revisions streamline the framework to better support different program types, including full-time virtual schools, blended learning environments, competency-based education, and other innovative instructional models.

APPLYING THE STANDARDS IN YOUR SETTING

The National Standards for Quality Online Teaching recognize the various roles and responsibilities of online educators and the unique contexts of various programs. Furthermore, not every standard or indicator is universally applicable. For example, some educators may operate within programs where modifying curriculum or course content is not part of their role. In these cases, they can focus on a subset of indicators that align with their specific responsibilities.

This flexibility is intentional. It ensures that the standards serve as a versatile resource, whether for professional development, self-evaluation, or crafting evaluation rubrics tailored to distinct teaching contexts. Programs can adapt the standards to

meet their needs, adopting only the relevant indicators without diminishing the overall value of the framework.

Programs do not need to apply every standard to benefit fully. The standards are designed to support growth and adaptation over time. As programs evolve and teacher roles expand, additional standards and indicators can be incorporated to align with new goals and responsibilities. By emphasizing this adaptability, the National Standards for Quality Online Teaching empowers educators and organizations to leverage the framework in ways that best suit their unique needs and settings.

WHAT'S NEW IN THIS REVISION

This edition includes several significant updates to better reflect the evolving needs of online teaching:

- **Restructured Standards:** The original eight standards have been consolidated into five, with indicators organized by increasing complexity.
- **Renamed Standards:** The former Standard F: Diverse Instruction is now Standard D: Learner-Centered Instruction, emphasizing the needs of all learners, including those with disabilities. The new Standard C: Engagement and Belonging combines elements of the previous Community Building and Learner Engagement standards.
- **Deleted Standards:** The Digital Pedagogy and

Assessment and Measurement standards have been removed, with their indicators integrated into other standards for a more streamlined approach.

- **Revised Language:** Indicators have been reworded to clearly delineate “What” (the indicator itself), “Why” (Intent), and “How” (Application). This helps ensure clarity, measurability, and practical relevance. The terms Intent and Application have replaced the former Explanations and Examples used in past versions of the standards. The term Application is not intended to imply a mandatory requirement but rather to provide illustrative examples of how the indicator might be effectively implemented.

SUPPORTING RESOURCES

To further enhance usability, the National Standards for Quality (NSQ) team publishes Standards in Practice (S.I.P.) documents each month. These resources spotlight individual indicators, sharing practitioner insights, practical tools, and strategies for implementation.

Additional resources, including a crosswalk of changes made during this revision, a crosswalk of the NSQ Teaching Standards and the Charlotte Danielson frameworks, and other supporting materials, are continually added to the NSQOL website at www.nsqol.org.

The National Standards for Quality Online Teaching are identified on the following pages.

THE NATIONAL STANDARDS FOR QUALITY ONLINE TEACHING ARE ORGANIZED INTO THE FOLLOWING FIVE STANDARDS:



Standard A: Professional Responsibilities



Standard B: Digital Citizenship



Standard C: Engagement and Belonging



Standard D: Learner-Centered Instruction



Standard E: Instructional Design



STANDARD A: PROFESSIONAL RESPONSIBILITIES

The online teacher demonstrates professional competence by adhering to professional responsibilities.

A1

The online teacher meets or is working towards local and/or state/national requirements for eligibility to teach.

INTENT

Professional teaching standards may include state or teaching requirements specific to teaching online.

The teacher demonstrates knowledge of the subject area(s) and pedagogy appropriate for learners.

APPLICATION

The teacher holds credentials in the field of study they are teaching.

The teacher has a valid teaching certificate.

The teacher is actively working towards their alternative certification.

A2

The online teacher demonstrates technological proficiency.

INTENT

The teacher applies troubleshooting skills to effectively teach and support learners in an online course.

The teacher has the knowledge to serve as the first point of contact when learners need unexpected problem-solving with accessing and using technology.

APPLICATION

Basic troubleshooting skills may require the online teacher to assist learners with passwords, plug-ins, and other course-related technology tools.

Should the teacher need assistance with technology, she knows how to contact local technology support. Additionally, the teacher can direct learners to the appropriate support if it is beyond program expectations for a teacher.

A3

The online teacher adheres to local or national laws or mandates related to the safety and success of all learners.

INTENT

Online teachers, like all educators, are required to follow local and/or national laws (ex. American's with Disabilities Act (ADA), the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), Section 508, the Children's Online Protection Act (COPA), the Children's Internet Protection Act (CIPA), Family Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), etc.) to protect the learners' rights to privacy and promote success in the online learning environment.

APPLICATION

The teacher maintains a communication log documenting contacts with site mentors, parents/guardians support. The teacher maintains records of communications with learners and encourages learners to respond to any teacher-initiated communications.

The teacher uses school-provided logs for documenting parent/guardian/learning coach communication. As a back-up, they also save email messages and other records in on going, complex cases.

The teacher can work with the learners' local schools to understand disability service plans and then report to colleagues options for providing the most supportive learning environment.

A teacher who does not have access to the learner disability service information can work with a coordinator within the online program to ensure learners are provided with the most supportive learning environment.

The teacher works with the learners', after reviewing the IEP, reaches out to the school contact to ensure the learner has the adaptive technology required by the IEP. The online teacher also shares training videos on the hardware/software with the parent(s)/guardian(s)/learning coach(es).

The teacher creates examples of email address or social media handles for learners to review, critique, and reflect upon and shares their experience with creating online identities, which could be done in an orientation prior to the course or at the beginning of it.

The teacher maintains security of learner records/data by following local protocols for accessing sharing systems and communicating protected information with other stakeholders.

A4

The online teacher is a reflective practitioner.

INTENT

The online teacher is a reflective practitioner who continues to focus on their practice and finds opportunities for growth.

APPLICATION

The teacher seeks out opportunities for feedback/suggestions on areas of practice that, after reflection, demonstrate areas for growth.

The teacher actively seeks feedback from learners, peers, and supervisors to inform their teaching practice. For example, the teacher might administer an anonymous mid-course survey to gather learner perceptions about the content's pacing, clarity, and relevance of the content. Based on the feedback, the teacher reflects on their approach and makes necessary adjustments to improve the learning experience.

A5

The online teacher regularly participates in professional learning related to online learning and pedagogy.

INTENT

The teacher understands the importance of staying up to date in best practices in their ever-evolving field.

The teacher identifies areas for professional growth.

APPLICATION

The teacher participates in annual evaluations that show growth in meeting professional goals.

The teacher participates in professional learning groups/communities.

The teacher documents evidence of professional development and/or has evidence of meeting individual professional growth plan goals.

A6**The online teacher effectively manages their roles and responsibilities.****INTENT**

Effective management of resources, such as time, is essential to maintaining teacher well-being and ensuring consistent, high-quality support for learners.

Communication with stakeholders is essential for learner success.

Being visible is a critical role the teacher plays in the online class so that learners feel a sense of community.

The teacher seamlessly embeds tools that support the facilitation of online learning.

APPLICATION

The teacher structures their day by blocking out time for communication, feedback, and professional development.

The teacher is intentional with posting announcements daily, emailing learners and/or posting in discussion forums in a regular cadence.

The teacher establishes a daily routine that includes specific times for live synchronous reading groups, providing personalized feedback on learner work, and sending weekly progress updates to parents.

The teacher incorporates structured live sessions, such as morning meetings, where elementary learners can engage with their peers and teacher in a consistent, supportive environment.

The teacher uses visual schedules and reminder tools to help learners and parents navigate the weekly assignments and expectations.

A7**The online teacher models digital citizenship including the responsible use of emerging technologies.****INTENT**

Promoting positive digital citizenship helps ensure learners develop ethical, safe, and responsible online practices, contributing to a secure and welcoming online environment.

The teacher aligns classroom procedures concerning digital citizenship with program policies.

APPLICATION

Classroom procedures for digital citizenship are accessible in the digital classroom environment.

The teacher models how to attribute Creative Commons-licensed, open content/Open Educational Resources.

The teacher models expected behavior and does not present another's work as their own.

The teacher demonstrates responsible use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) by explaining how to use AI tools for research, brainstorming, or learning support, while emphasizing the importance of avoiding plagiarism, critically evaluating AI-generated content, and ensuring proper attribution when incorporating these tools into assignments.

During live class sessions or in discussion forums, the online teacher models appropriate communication practices, such as using respectful language, avoiding all caps (to prevent misinterpretation as shouting), and citing sources when sharing information. For example, when responding to a learner's question in a forum, the teacher cites a relevant resource to reinforce the importance of giving credit.

The teacher uses a private classroom tool to share resources and facilitate discussions, while modeling responsible behavior by setting clear guidelines about privacy, appropriate content sharing, and respectful interaction. For example, in a current events class, the teacher might demonstrate how to fact-check news articles before sharing them to ensure accuracy and credibility.

A8**The online teacher advocates for quality online learning with stakeholders.****INTENT**

The teacher advocates for quality online learning by modeling best practices in the online classroom and engaging with stakeholders beyond the school or team to promote innovation and effective practices in online education.

APPLICATION

The teacher serves as a mentor, leads a Professional Learning Community (PLC), or leads staff professional development.

The teacher participates in state or national conferences to present best practices and strategies for online teaching, highlighting the benefits and addressing common challenges of online learning to a broader audience.

The teacher contributes to professional publications, such as local newsletters, blogs, or SIP documents, to share best practices in online learning.

The teacher presents about online education at a local civic group's meeting.

**STANDARD B: DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP**

The online teacher facilitates learning experiences that model and promote digital citizenship while ensuring fair access and participation for all learners.

B1**The online teacher facilitates learning experiences that promote responsible digital citizenship for all learners.****INTENT**

The teacher understands that learners need age-appropriate instruction on digital citizenship skills.

Note: While teachers may not be able to create entirely new learning experiences, they can provide additional direction to learners through feedback and other communications.”

APPLICATION

The teacher facilitates learner investigations of the legal and ethical issues related to technology use in our global society.

The teacher instructs learners on how to protect their digital privacy and maintain their digital footprint (i.e. reviewing sharing/privacy settings) when using various technologies to complete assignments.

The teacher models and instructs on evaluating reliable sources and providing factual evidence when discussing issues.

The teacher shares a screencast or announcement demonstrating the appropriate use of generative AI resources in alignment with local guidelines/policies.

B2

The online teacher establishes expectations for learner behavior that encourage academic integrity and appropriate use of digital tools in adherence to local policies.

INTENT

Academic integrity includes responsible and honest behavior.

The teacher understands how the use of technology may lead to instances of academic dishonesty.

The teacher understands that learners need explicit instruction on how to apply local academic integrity policies in completing assignments.

APPLICATION

The teacher provides age-appropriate instruction/modeling to learners academic integrity and how to avoid claims of academic dishonesty.

The teacher is able to identify the risks of academic dishonesty in assignments and provides appropriate instructional support when incidents of academic dishonesty occur.

The teacher provides information about using and citing sources or other resources available, like plagiarism-checking tools.

The teacher communicates to learners and stakeholders about assessment procedures (passwords, test-taking conditions, etc.) set by local policy.

The teacher provides information and guidelines about acceptable generative AI use for classroom assignments.

B3

The online teacher models compliance with intellectual property policies and fair-use standards while fostering learner understanding and responsible application of these concepts.

INTENT

Teaching intellectual property and fair-use standards equips learners with the skills to ethically use and share digital content, fostering respect for creators, and compliance with legal guidelines.

Note: In, for example, courses that are already created, teachers may not be able to create learning experiences but can provide additional direction to learners through feedback and other communications.

APPLICATION

The teacher adheres to program policies by ensuring that created course materials align with intellectual property and fair use guidelines.

The teacher respects copyright law, demonstrates appropriate use, and models the use of correct citations in teacher-created materials.

The teacher does not share learner work or information without obtaining proper permission.

The teacher provides specific instructions or guidelines to learners regarding collaborative work and sharing of information.

The teacher has learners complete a module or unit on copyright and fair use and/or works with the school's librarian to review appropriate resources.

The teacher chooses additional tools to meet the learner's instructional needs that are also protective of student data and privacy.

B4

The online teacher implements national and local policies designed to safeguard all learners in digital learning environments.

INTENT

Adhering to local data security, privacy, and access policies ensures learners' personal information is protected and promotes trust and fairness in the online environment.

Individual schools and organizations have varying procedures and policies on how they protect learner data. Examples of these policies might include: Family Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), the Children's Online Protection Act (COPA), the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), and the Acceptable Use Policy (AUP), etc.

APPLICATION

The teacher communicates to learners and stakeholders about local assessment procedures (passwords, test-taking conditions, etc.).

The teacher follows the program's policy/guidelines for sharing information about a learner's progress with other stakeholders in ways that protect the individual learner's privacy.

The teacher is responsible for implementing effective strategies to secure learner data based on program policies.



STANDARD C: ENGAGEMENT AND BELONGING

The online teacher cultivates learner success by promoting meaningful engagement to build a supportive online community where learners feel connected, valued, and motivated to learn.

C1

The online teacher provides and/or directs learners to technical support in a prompt manner.

INTENT

A common barrier to learner engagement in online learning is the inability to access the online learning space and/or required technology.

The teacher is responsible for helping learners to navigate the course platform and perform the required tasks within the course.

Additionally, the online teacher knows how and when to direct learners to the appropriate advanced local technology support.

APPLICATION

The teacher guides students in accessing login credentials according to program guidelines.

The teacher provides basic troubleshooting tips to learners for specific tools used within the online environment.

The teacher directs learners to use the program's help desk for technical support issues.

The teacher provides a screencast showing learners how to submit an assignment with media.

The teacher provides directions on how to contact local technology support, which may take the form of a help desk or ticket system, so learners can get advanced technological support and access to technology as various situations arise.

The teacher ensures that learners know where to find feedback from their instructor.

C2**The online teacher identifies patterns in learner engagement.****INTENT**

The teacher understands that learner engagement contributes to the learner's academic success, and as such, monitors engagement data to inform potential interventions.

The teacher needs to be able to analyze and interpret a wide range of data provided in the learning management system (LMS), adaptive software, and other digital tools. Further, the online teacher needs to be able to identify patterns in the data that can inform interventions to maximize each learner's engagement.

APPLICATION

The teacher establishes a consistent process for tracking learner engagement using tools within the learning management system (LMS), learner information system, or dashboards. These tools provide metrics such as attendance, participation in synchronous lessons and instructional activities, time spent in the program, lessons completed, and specific areas of focus during instructional time. By analyzing this data, the teacher identifies patterns in engagement and uses it to set goals collaboratively with learners to enhance their participation and achievement.

The teacher uses engagement analytics from discussion forums and collaborative tools to identify learners who are less active, initiating outreach to provide targeted support and resources to re-engage them in the learning process.

C3**The online teacher nurtures individual learner agency.****INTENT**

Frameworks like the Universal Design for Learning emphasize the need for learner agency for optimal learning.

It is important for teachers to promote learner agency by jointly setting goals and conferencing with them about their progress toward the goals that have been set. This buy-in is an important part of motivation (see Self-Determination Theory) as opposed to teachers themselves setting all the goals and simply monitoring learner progress themselves.

APPLICATION

The teacher regularly confers with each learner to establish individual goals regarding performance on mastery outcomes, and then follows up to encourage the learner regarding progress towards those goals.

The teacher uses multiple tools to identify learner preferences and interests to support their needs and goals.

The teacher uses the information gathered to model and promote learners taking responsibility and ownership of and for their learning. The teacher monitors learner progress, growth, and movement along the continuum of developing agency.

The teacher enables a learner-customized pace and/or path through instruction aligned with learners' individual goals, learning trajectories, and/or interests.

The teacher allows and suggests various ways for learners to interact with and express knowledge of content to encourage learner agency.

C4**The online teacher communicates in a timely and supportive manner.****INTENT**

Effective communication methods are necessary regardless of whom the online teacher is communicating.

Regardless of who the online teacher is communicating with, effective communication methods are necessary.

The teacher strategically selects communication formats—such as text, audio, or video—to ensure timely, supportive, and audience-specific interactions.

APPLICATION

At the start of the course, the online teacher fosters a sense of belonging by communicating in a welcoming and authentic manner, helping learners recognize the teacher as a real, supportive person who is invested in their success. This intentional engagement continues throughout the term, with ongoing interactions designed to support and connect with learners.

The teacher establishes and maintains appropriate channels of communication with learners in accordance with program policies (including expectations around frequency, response time, methods, etc).

The teacher selects appropriate communication methods (video and voice recordings) for non-readers and/or English learners to ensure communication is supportive and reaches all stakeholders.

The teacher responds to learners' course-related questions via age-appropriate communication methods.

C5**The online teacher provides actionable, specific, and timely feedback.****INTENT**

Actionable, specific, and timely feedback positively impacts learning.

As the content expert, the online teacher is responsible for helping learners master the course content via feedback.

APPLICATION

Following a project-based learning unit, the online teacher uses screencast recordings to provide learners with specific feedback on their portfolio pages.

The teacher uses markup tools within the LMS to embed actionable and specific feedback within submitted assignments.

The teacher provides feedback within a specified time so that learner progression isn't hindered.

C6**The online teacher provides and/or facilitates the development of community engagement expectations.****INTENT**

Fostering a sense of community through trust and effective communication supports learner engagement, collaboration, and a positive online experience.

Expectations for acceptable online behavior are needed to ensure that learners interact appropriately, safely, and constructively, especially in varied environments.

APPLICATION

The teacher works with learners to set goals, expectations, and roles for appropriate interaction with peers in the online classroom.

The teacher models and gives explicit instruction for online discussion forums regarding etiquette and provides feedback about how learners should communicate with each other.

The teacher ensures learners take turns leading discussions by assigning rotating roles, such as facilitator, summarizer, or question-asker, to ensure all voices are represented.

C7

The online teacher facilitates collaboration among learners.

INTENT

An essential component of online teaching is creating a collaborative community conducive to active learning, where learners can openly communicate and work together to achieve a mutual objective.

In addition, it is important that online learners feel a sense of belonging, control, and care created by the teacher, which is accomplished through effective facilitation.

Learner-learner interaction may take place in group activities, such as projects, discussions, and instruction. An important component to building higher-order thinking skills among learners is facilitating their interaction in online settings, particularly in groups, projects, and/or discussions to allow for collaborative interaction.

Once a sense of community is established, active learning such as authentic assessment and peer-to-peer discovery can take place.

APPLICATION

The teacher uses active learning strategies, such as collaborative group projects where learners design and present solutions to real-world problems, or small group work focused on peer-reviewing assignments to cultivate interaction.

The teacher encourages learners who are not actively engaged to the collaborative activity to share their ideas within the safe space of group discussion.

The teacher follows up with active online discussion, posing deeper questions to push learners' thinking forward.

The teacher intentionally plans learner-to-learner interactions to help foster collaborations through real-world projects, practical creation of solutions, and discussions encouraging analysis, synthesis, and evaluation of perspectives from a wide range of learners.

The teacher may use online resources and active learning strategies, including peer-based learning, inquiry-based activities, collaborative learning, discussion groups, and small group work to cultivate collaboration.

C8**The online teacher responds quickly to violations of the community engagement expectations.****INTENT**

It is important for online teachers to enforce guidelines for acceptable online behavior to ensure that learners are interacting in an appropriate, safe, and constructive manner, especially in varied environments. The online teacher must maintain an active presence to monitor interactions in both asynchronous and synchronous online settings.

APPLICATION

The teacher follows the program's policies for responding to inappropriate comments on class discussion boards.

The teacher uses live chat moderation tools during synchronous class sessions to immediately address inappropriate language or behavior, sending a private message to the learner involved and reporting the incident according to the program's guidelines.

C9**The online teacher leverages partnerships with stakeholders within the learner's local learning community.****INTENT**

Online learners are supported by various stakeholders, including parents/guardians, learning coaches, on-site facilitators, counselors, and other learner support staff.

The teacher partners with all stakeholder groups to support the learner and their progress.

Communication should be ongoing, open, proactive, and continuous. It should also address both learner successes and challenges and be documented appropriately.

APPLICATION

The teacher encourages parents/guardians/learning coaches to use the available technology tools (e.g., LMS and/or student information system (SIS), parent/guardian/learning coach portals) to monitor the learner's progress in the course.

The teacher communicates various study practices with parents/guardians/learning coaches that they can use to support their child.

The teacher communicates concerns about the learner's grade to all pertinent stakeholders.

The teacher partners with special education and technology support staff to ensure learners can access assistive technologies as needed.

The teacher reaches out to school guidance counselors and/or social workers to address concerns related to a learner's well-being.

The teacher maintains a communication log documenting contact with stakeholders. The teacher maintains a record of communications with learners and encourages them to respond to teacher-initiated communications.



STANDARD D: LEARNER-CENTERED INSTRUCTION

The online teacher personalizes instruction based on the learner's academic, social, and emotional needs.

D1

The online teacher collaborates with stakeholders.

INTENT

Teachers should engage stakeholders in order to ensure alignment between course objectives and the learners' needs.

Collaboration between the online teacher and stakeholders is critical in order to personalize instruction to meet individual learner needs.

APPLICATION

After reviewing the IEP or 504 accommodations, the teacher contacts the school to ensure the learner has the required adaptive technology. The online teacher also shares training videos on the hardware/software with the parent/guardian, as required.

The teacher works with their data department to extract useful, actionable data from the LMS regarding learner behavior and makes adjustments.

The teacher analyzes data that demonstrating that learners who submit their assignments within three days of the timeline score higher than those who miss this window. The teacher implements incentives and increases communications with families to encourage learners to submit assignments within three days of the due date.

The teacher collaborates with parents/guardians/learning coach during virtual conferences to set realistic academic goals and strategies, such as establishing study schedules or identifying preferred learning tools.

D2

The online teacher builds an understanding of the learner's needs and preferences.

INTENT

Personalizing learning ensures that instruction addresses each learner's unique strengths and challenges, fostering growth and achievement.

The teacher personalizes instruction by understanding the learner's academic, social, and emotional needs through ongoing data collection and feedback.

APPLICATION

For example, after analyzing benchmarks, the teacher observes that an English Language Learner (ELL) isn't making adequate progress and that unfamiliarity with English is the reason. The online teacher then provides additional support using effective strategies for English Language Learners.

The teacher creates learner surveys, polls, check-in calls, live sessions, etc. to inform him or her of learner learning progress and instructional needs.

The teacher conducts pre-course surveys to identify learner preferences and uses the data to customize instructional strategies.

The teacher provides opportunities for learners to choose activities aligned with their interests and preferences.

D3**The online teacher supports the learner's use of assistive technologies.****INTENT**

The teacher advocates for the learner in order to ensure the learner has access to assistive technologies.

The teacher ensures that all learners can access and use assistive technologies effectively to overcome barriers to learning.

APPLICATION

The teacher selects supplementary materials, such as accessible PDFs, eBooks with text-to-speech functionality, or closed-captioned instructional videos, to ensure compatibility with screen readers.

The teacher shares training videos and guides for learners and parents on how to use assistive technologies like screen readers or speech-to-text tools.

The teacher collaborates with tech support staff to troubleshoot accessibility issues and provide real-time assistance.

D4**The online teacher continuously monitors learner progress.****INTENT**

The teacher tracks learner progress as the foundation for informing future modifications needed to support learner success.

The teacher collaborates with other stakeholders to determine learner progress.

Note: The application examples in D4-D7 contain the same four situations with sequential teacher actions threaded through the indicators.

APPLICATION

The teacher reviews the IEP goals for a learner weekly, tracking progress on accommodations such as extended time on assignments. (Special Education Student)

A teacher notices a learner's grades suddenly drop while reviewing daily assignments. (Unexpected Change)

The teacher tracks weekly reading proficiency levels by analyzing engagement in group discussions, pre-tests, and weekly assignments. (Reading Proficiency)

The teacher monitors the learner's behavior, noting off-topic posts in discussion forums and low participation in activities. (Student Engagement)

D5**The online teacher analyzes a variety of data sources.****INTENT**

Analyzing multiple data sources allows the teacher to identify trends, address gaps, and implement targeted strategies to optimize learner success.

The teacher has a standard process for tracking and reporting data of individuals' academic progress in consideration of remediation, nearing mastery, or achieved mastery. This data helps to set goals and maintain appropriate academic progress.

The teacher analyzes and applies data from multiple data points to make informed decisions about instruction and learner support.

APPLICATION

The teacher examines data from multiple sources, including engagement metrics and formative assessments, to ensure the IEP goals are met. Adjustments are made collaboratively with stakeholders as needed. (Special Education Student)

After noticing a sudden drop in a learner's grades, the online teacher reviews participation data and reaches out to the learner's parent/guardian/learning coach and learns that the learner lost internet access at home for a week after a hurricane. (Unexpected Change)

Data patterns, such as low scores on vocabulary quizzes or limited participation in reading discussions, reveal areas where the student struggles with vocabulary and comprehension. (Reading Proficiency)

Patterns in engagement and performance data patterns indicate that the learner is disengaged due to boredom. The teacher consults with the learner's parent/guardian/learning coach and program coordinators to address the issue. (Student Engagement)

D6

The online teacher creates or adapts curricular materials in response to the learner's needs.

INTENT

Based on data analysis, the teacher adapts curricular materials to meet the learner's needs.

In alignment with the course objectives, the online teacher responds to learner engagement and performance data by adjusting curriculum materials.

APPLICATION

The teacher modifies assessment rubrics to reflect IEP accommodations, such as reduced answer choices for multiple-choice questions or alternative formats for assignments. (Special Education Student)

The teacher exempts the learner from specific assignments missed during the internet outage and provides alternative resources to catch up. (Unexpected Change)

The teacher introduces leveled readers and multimedia resources, such as interactive digital storybooks and vocabulary-building apps, tailored to the student's reading level. These activities include word-matching games and digital flashcards to reinforce learning. (Reading Proficiency)

The teacher adapts an assignment to include a project-based learning activity aligned with the learner's interests, such as allowing the choice of a challenging novel for a literature project. (Student Engagement)

D7

The online teacher modifies instructional strategies in response to the learner's needs.

INTENT

Based on data analysis, the teacher adapts instructional strategies in response to the learner's needs.

The teacher dynamically adjusts teaching strategies to address individual learner needs.

The teacher ensures that all learners, regardless of their abilities or backgrounds, can engage with the material, stay motivated, and achieve their learning goals.

APPLICATION

The teacher incorporates gamification elements to encourage engagement and adjusts lesson delivery methods (e.g., using multimedia presentations) to align with the learner's learning preferences. (Special Education Student)

Deadlines for assignments are extended, and the teacher schedules one-on-one virtual check-ins to help the learner stay on track while providing emotional support. (Unexpected Change)

The teacher adjusts instructional strategies by incorporating small group reading sessions and one-on-one tutoring to support the learner's comprehension and engagement. (Reading Proficiency)

The teacher implements personalized learning paths, providing differentiated tasks and opportunities for leadership in group activities to re-engage the learner and address behavioral concerns. (Student Engagement)



STANDARD E: INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN

The online teacher curates and creates instructional materials, tools, strategies, and resources to engage all learners and ensure the achievement of academic goals.

This standard and indicators are considered optional, as instructional design does not always fall under online teaching responsibilities. Some programs do not allow teachers to design or modify course content. Because teachers may lack formal training in instructional design principles, the intent and application statements provide more context and details. For full online course design standards, see the National Standards for Quality Online Courses. The following section outlines indicators for instructional design skills for the online teacher of record, where applicable.

E1

The online teacher aligns course content with associated learning goals.

INTENT

Aligning course content with associated learning goals ensures that instructional materials and activities are purposeful, focused, and directly support the desired outcomes. This alignment helps learners understand what is expected of them, promotes coherence throughout the course, and ensures that all content contributes meaningfully to academic success. It also enables teachers to effectively assess learner progress and make informed adjustments to instruction as needed.

APPLICATION

Learning targets appropriately align with course objectives.

The teacher reviews formative and summative assessments and tracks items that do not align with the content and need to be removed or revised.

The teacher develops a curriculum alignment map to ensure that each course activity directly supports specific learning goals.

The teacher designs assessments that clearly measure learners' mastery of the learning goals.

The teacher organizes the course content in a logical sequence that builds upon previous lessons and standards, ensuring each module prepares learners for the next level of understanding.

The teacher selects or creates resources (e.g., videos, readings, interactive activities) that are directly linked to the learning goals.

E2**The online teacher incorporates subject-specific resources.****INTENT**

Incorporating subject-specific resources enhances the relevance and authenticity of the learning experience, helping learners connect content to real-world applications within the discipline. These resources deepen understanding by providing context, examples, and perspectives unique to the subject area. By leveraging specialized materials, the online teacher ensures learners are engaged with accurate, meaningful, and discipline-specific content that supports mastery of learning goals.

APPLICATION

Use of pedagogy and knowledge of content are evident in teacher-provided feedback.

The teacher uses pedagogical content knowledge to identify common errors/misconceptions in the course topics and includes appropriate discipline-specific resources to minimize learner's errors/misconceptions.

The teacher integrates academic articles, research papers, or textbooks specific to the subject area to deepen learners' understanding. For example, in a history course, the teacher might provide primary source documents, such as letters, speeches, or treaties, to give learners first-hand insight into historical events, enhancing their connection to the content and developing their analytical skills.

The teacher incorporates tools and simulations that are specific to the subject, such as interactive physics simulations or virtual labs. For instance, in a chemistry class, the teacher might use an online lab tool where learners can simulate chemical reactions, allowing them to explore complex concepts in a virtual environment.

The teacher invites professionals in his or her respective field to discuss "a day in the life" in order to give learners an idea of real-world applications of the subject they are studying.

E3**The online teacher incorporates developmentally appropriate resources.****INTENT**

Incorporating developmentally appropriate resources ensures that instructional materials and activities are tailored to the cognitive, social, and emotional needs of the learners. This approach helps learners engage meaningfully with the content, build on prior knowledge, and develop skills at a pace that supports their growth. By using age-appropriate language, complexity, and formats, the online teacher fosters a supportive learning environment where all learners can thrive.

APPLICATION

The teacher includes content to which learners can relate. For example, a 4th-grade class reads a history passage on topics that would be encountered by 4th and 5th-grade learners rather than seniors in high school.

The teacher evaluates the appropriateness of content by making sure it is free of adult content, unnecessary advertisements, and bias before including it in the discussion forum.

The teacher includes resources at the appropriate reading and comprehension level for the grade level of the learners engaging with it.

The teacher designs activities that gradually increase in complexity, ensuring they match the learners' cognitive development. For example, in a middle school math course, the teacher may start with basic arithmetic exercises and then move on to more complex algebra problems, providing step-by-step instructions and hints. This scaffolding ensures learners build foundational skills before advancing to more challenging content.

The teacher incorporates multimedia resources such as videos, interactive simulations, or infographics that are tailored to the developmental stage of the learners. For example, in an elementary science class, the teacher might use simple, visually engaging animations to explain basic concepts like the water cycle, while in a high school science class, the teacher might use more detailed models or case studies to explain advanced topics like climate change. This ensures that the content is accessible and engaging for learners at different developmental levels.

E4**The online teacher incorporates resources that are representative of the learners.****INTENT**

Incorporating resources that are representative of the learners ensures that all learners see their identities, cultures, and experiences reflected in the course content. This approach promotes a sense of belonging, validates different perspectives, and fosters an supportive learning environment. By using representative resources, the online teacher encourages engagement, reduces barriers to learning, and empowers learners to connect more deeply with the material.

APPLICATION

The teacher uses resources that reflect the backgrounds and experiences of today's learners in his or her classes.

The teacher incorporates a variety of multimedia resources, such as videos, articles, and case studies, that reflect a range of perspectives and experiences. For example, in a social studies course, the teacher might include readings and videos from different cultural perspectives about a historical event, ensuring that learners see their own backgrounds represented and gain a broader understanding of the subject matter.

In an English or literature course, the online teacher curates a reading list that includes works by authors with a range of perspectives and life experiences. This could include novels, poetry, or essays from different regions of the world or voices from underrepresented groups, giving learners a chance to connect personally with the material and see themselves reflected in the curriculum.

The teacher designs discussion questions or assignments that draw on learners' own experiences, backgrounds, and interests. For example, in a science class, the teacher might ask learners to explore how scientific topics, like climate change or public health, affect their local communities or cultural practices. This allows learners to contribute from their unique perspectives and deepens their engagement with the content.

E5**The online teacher designs courses with continuous assessment opportunities.****INTENT**

Designing courses with continuous assessment opportunities allows the online teacher to monitor learner progress regularly and provide timely feedback to support learning. These assessments help identify areas where learners are excelling and where they need additional support, fostering a growth-oriented approach. Continuous assessment also encourages learners to reflect on their learning, stay engaged, and take an active role in their academic development, ultimately ensuring the achievement of learning goals.

Note: Programs may determine the appropriate instruments according to their LMS and the role of the online teacher in creating and/or implementing assessments.

APPLICATION

The teacher uses a variety of assessments (formative and summative) to measure learner progress and allow multiple opportunities for learners to master learning goals.

The teacher adds formative assessments to the courses, which encourage learners to check their knowledge and ask questions as needed.

The teacher determines the appropriate assessment tools as allowed by the LMS and knows his or her role in creating/implementing assessments.

The teacher uses a variety of self-assessment strategies, including reflections, rubrics, graphic organizers, oral assessments, and targets.

The teacher creates surveys or polls to gather learner feedback on a lesson. The online teacher is open to reviewing learner feedback and data to determine if a lesson may be better presented synchronously rather than asynchronously in the future.

E6**The online teacher designs curricular materials that incorporate constructive feedback.****INTENT**

Incorporating constructive feedback into curriculum design helps students refine their understanding and build confidence through actionable guidance.

APPLICATION

The teacher designs assignments that encourage learners to provide constructive feedback to each other. For example, in a writing course, learners might submit drafts of their essays, and then provide feedback on their peers' work using a rubric provided by the teacher. This process not only allows learners to improve their own work based on peer feedback but also helps them develop critical thinking and communication skills, all while reinforcing the importance of constructive criticism.

The teacher incorporates quizzes or assignments with automated feedback, offering immediate, specific guidance on learners' answers. For instance, in a math course, after a learner completes a problem set, the system provides tailored feedback explaining why their answer was correct or incorrect, offering hints, and guiding them toward the correct method. This immediate, constructive feedback helps learners identify mistakes and improve their understanding in real-time.

The teacher designs assignments where learners submit drafts or stages of their work and receive targeted feedback before submitting the final version. For example, in a project-based course, learners might submit an outline or a rough draft, receive constructive feedback from the teacher or peers, and use that feedback to revise and improve their work before submitting the final project. This iterative process helps learners refine their ideas and improve their work over time.

The teacher facilitates discussion forums where learners engage with the course content and each other. In these forums, the teacher provides specific, constructive feedback on learners' contributions, highlighting strengths and offering suggestions for deeper analysis or improvement. For example, in a philosophy course, the teacher might respond to a learner's post by acknowledging insightful points and offering probing questions to encourage further critical thinking. This feedback helps learners refine their ideas and develop stronger arguments throughout the course.

E7**The online teacher develops a range of assessments.****INTENT**

Developing a range of assessments ensures that learners have multiple opportunities to demonstrate their understanding and skills in different ways. This approach accommodates different learning preferences, reduces bias, and provides a comprehensive picture of learner progress. By using varied assessment methods, such as formative, summative, performance-based, and self-assessments, the online teacher fosters engagement, supports individual needs, and ensures a fair evaluation of learning.

No assessment is perfect, so multiple and varied assessments give a clearer picture of progress.

Note: The options for assessment instruments available to teachers will vary according to the LMS used. Teacher access to learner assessment data may vary.

APPLICATION

The teacher uses a variety of formative and summative assessments.

The teacher knows and understands the reach of authentic assessments (i.e., the opportunity to demonstrate understanding of acquired knowledge and skills, as opposed to testing isolated skills or retained facts) and are included as part of the evaluation process.

The teacher uses a variety of formative and summative assessments, which could include auto-graded assessments, learner projects, videos, learner-created multimedia, embedded self-checks, portfolios, or live presentations.

The teacher uses a school-created or endorsed exam for a concept but also asks the learners in small group but also asks the learners in a discussion thread to share something they learned that was not on the test.

E8

The online teacher designs learning experiences that efficiently use technology.

INTENT

Designing learning experiences that efficiently use technology maximizes the potential of digital tools to enhance learner engagement, collaboration, and learning outcomes. By selecting and integrating technology purposefully, the online teacher ensures that it supports, rather than distracts from, the instructional goals. Efficient use of technology fosters a more streamlined and interactive learning environment, providing learners with accessible, flexible, and innovative ways to engage with content and demonstrate mastery.

APPLICATION

Wherever possible, the online teacher provides opportunities for learners to engage in social learning, global networks, and classroom-to-classroom connections. The online teacher makes assignments active, allowing learners to build, design, create, and investigate.

The teacher uses technology to increase learner engagement by giving learners control over their interactions with media.

The teacher designs lessons that combine videos, quizzes, and interactive simulations. This use of technology engages learners in an active, hands-on learning experience while maintaining a clear connection to the learning objectives.

The teacher integrates collaborative tools like discussion boards, shared documents, or group projects using platforms such as Google Docs or Padlet. For example, in a literature class, learners might work together in small groups to annotate a reading passage in real-time, discuss their insights through a forum, and create a digital presentation. These tools encourage teamwork, communication, and critical thinking while efficiently using technology to facilitate collaboration and peer learning.

E9

The online teacher continuously reviews and updates course content.

INTENT

Regular updates to course content ensure learners receive accurate, current, and engaging material that aligns with evolving standards and best practices.

APPLICATION

The teacher regularly updates course materials to include the latest research, news articles, or case studies relevant to the subject matter.

Based on learner surveys, discussions, or assessments, the teacher adjusts course content to address areas where learners may be struggling. If many learners express difficulty with a particular topic or concept, the online teacher updates the lessons, provides additional resources, or clarifies content to improve understanding.

The teacher explores and incorporates new educational technologies or tools that enhance learner engagement and learning. For example, the teacher might integrate a new interactive simulation or a learning management system functionality that provides more effective ways for learners to explore and engage with the course content. This ensures that technology use remains up-to-date and effective for the learning experience.

STANDARDS AND INDICATORS FROM THE NATIONAL STANDARDS FOR QUALITY ONLINE TEACHING



STANDARD A: PROFESSIONAL RESPONSIBILITIES

The online teacher demonstrates professional competence by adhering to professional responsibilities.

- A1** The online teacher meets or is working towards local and/or state/national requirements for eligibility to teach.
- A2** The online teacher demonstrates technological proficiency.
- A3** The online teacher adheres to local or national laws or mandates related to the safety and success of all students.
- A4** The online teacher is a reflective practitioner.
- A5** The online teacher regularly participates in professional learning related to online learning and pedagogy.
- A6** The online teacher effectively manages their roles and responsibilities.
- A7** The online teacher models digital citizenship including the responsible use of emerging technologies.
- A8** The online teacher advocates for quality online learning with stakeholders.



STANDARD B: DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP

The online teacher facilitates learning experiences that model and promote digital citizenship while ensuring fair access and participation for all learners.

- B1** The online teacher facilitates learning experiences that promote responsible digital citizenship for all learners.
- B2** The online teacher establishes expectations for learner behavior that encourage academic integrity and appropriate use of digital tools in adherence to local policies.
- B3** The online teacher models compliance with intellectual property policies and fair-use standards while fostering learner understanding and responsible application of these concepts.
- B4** The online teacher implements national and local policies designed to safeguard all learners in digital learning environments.



STANDARD C: ENGAGEMENT AND BELONGING

The online course incorporates instructional materials, activities, resources, and assessments that align with standards, engage all learners, and support the achievement of academic goals.

- C1** The online teacher provides and/or directs learners to technical support in a prompt manner.
- C2** The online teacher identifies patterns in learner engagement.
- C3** The online teacher nurtures individual learner agency.
- C4** The online teacher communicates in a timely and supportive manner.
- C5** The online teacher provides actionable, specific, and timely feedback.
- C6** The online teacher provides and/or facilitates the development of community engagement expectations.
- C7** The online teacher facilitates collaboration among learners.
- C8** The online teacher responds quickly to violations of the community engagement expectations.
- C9** The online teacher leverages partnerships with stakeholders within the student's local learning community.



STANDARD D: LEARNER-CENTERED INSTRUCTION

The online teacher personalizes instruction based on the learner's academic, social, and emotional needs.

- D1** The online teacher collaborates with stakeholders.
- D2** The online teacher builds an understanding of the learner's needs and preferences.
- D3** The online teacher supports the learner's use of assistive technologies.
- D4** The online teacher continuously monitors learner progress.
- D5** The online teacher analyzes a variety of data sources.
- D6** The online teacher creates or adapts curricular materials in response to the learner's needs.
- D7** The online teacher modifies instructional strategies in response to the learner's needs.



STANDARD E: INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN

The online teacher curates and creates instructional materials, tools, strategies, and resources to engage all learners and ensure the achievement of academic goals.

This standard and indicators are considered optional, as instructional design does not always fall under online teaching responsibilities. For full online course design standards, see the National Standards for Quality Online Courses. The following section outlines standards for instructional design skills for the online teacher of record, where applicable.

- E1** The online teacher aligns course content with associated learning goals.
- E2** The online teacher incorporates subject-specific resources.
- E3** The online teacher incorporates developmentally appropriate resources.
- E4** The online teacher incorporates resources that are representative of the learners.
- E5** The online teacher designs courses with continuous assessment opportunities.
- E6** The online teacher designs curricular materials that incorporate constructive feedback.
- E7** The online teacher develops a range of assessments.
- E8** The online teacher designs learning experiences that efficiently use technology.
- E9** The online teacher continuously reviews and updates course content.